



Smartphones up to 15k

After the launch of Moto G (1st gen) earlier this year, the mid-range smartphone segment lay open to innovation. In the aftermath we saw phone manufacturers go wild with specifications, screen sizes, SoCs, cameras, just about everything that can be quantified in a phone. The year brought various phones from Indian manufacturers as well as from old timers like Nokia, Sony, Samsung and LG.

This year we also saw an invasion of the Chinese companies like Xiaomi, which brought the Mi3 taking the market by storm. With its flagship like specs, mid-range price and limited stocks, the phone saw multiple flash sales ending in seconds. ZTE also launched its V5 smartphone this year, another decent performer. Asus came up with a brilliant line-up of phones, entering the thick of things.

We have news that the coming year will bring the new Zenfone range from Asus. Phones with 64-bit processing prowess may also hit stores in the budget segment. Next year would be another battle of the mid-rangers, with better specs and more cut-throat pricing.



Motorola Moto G (2nd gen)

Price: ₹12,999



Asus Zenfone 5

Price: ₹12,999



◀ **MICROMAX
CANVAS NITRO**

Price: ₹11,589

Zero 1 Winner

Micromax Canvas Nitro

At first glance the Micromax Canvas Nitro may not look as fancy as its other competitors in the market but as wise people say "Never judge a book by its cover". Micromax Canvas Nitro is a performer, period. While every other phone manufacturer is fiddling with a quad-core SoC in this category the Nitro is packing a 1.66 GHz octa-core MediaTek SoC, which churns out performance like not other. The device also has 2GB RAM and 8GB internal storage, the phone has a 5-inch 720p display. We put the phone through some rigorous usage, with games and 1080p videos, sometimes simultaneously, but were unable to find any lag in the performance of the phone. The 13 MP rear camera is the best in the category, and only the ZTE V5 comes close. You would be thinking the battery would be dead by now but surprise surprise, the Canvas Nitro gives almost 14 hours of battery life. So, if it's performance that you're after then this is it.

Second...

Motorola Moto G (2nd gen)

Motorola Moto G (2nd gen) is based on the tried and tested recipe of a handsome looking phone with decent specs and low price. The new version from Motorola is packing a Qualcomm Snapdragon 400 quad-core SoC clocked at 1.2GHz. The graphics part is handled by the Adreno 305 GPU and there is 16GB of internal storage (expandable to 32GB) and 1GB of RAM. All this doesn't sound that much on paper but it performs flawlessly in the real world and we didn't have any hiccups while we tested the smartphone. The camera and the display in the smartphone are not its plus points and could have been better. Maybe Motorola will become wiser when they launch a new version for this much liked phone.

Third...

Asus Zenfone 5

If we were giving out best design awards for budget category smartphones, the Asus Zenfone 5 would have won it in a heartbeat. The good looking phone from Asus is running on Intel's Z2560, which is a 1.6GHz dual-core processor. We were quite impressed that a dual-core phone which was able to compete with the likes of quad and octa cores. The phone also has 2GB of RAM and commendable build quality. Though we generally like stock Android over any UI, the Zen UI does make a compelling case for itself. With CES 2015 round the corner, we have news that Asus will be refreshing the Zenfone lineup, maybe it would stand a better chance at winning then.